years, he left Agra and began to ride south towards Malwa.

Word had reached his court that Abdullah Khan the Uzbek, who had replaced Adham Khan and Pir Muhammad in Malwa, was showing worrying signs of independence. No details are given, but Akbar thought the matter serious enough to warrant personal investigation. Still, this was not the secret and lightning dash he had once made with a handful of men to reach Adham Khan. It was, instead, a well-attended, leisurely journey, in which the hunting of wild elephants occupied the padishah as much as the chastisement of restive chiefs.

'A separate volume would be required,' Abul Fazl once wrote, 'to describe [the elephant's] . . . [wondrous] deeds' – and it is something of a marvel that Akbar didn't commission him to write one, so evident is the padishah's boundless love for the animal.

Pure joy animates the few days of Akbar's journey spent in elephant-rich forests near Narwar, in which the 'closeness of the trees and the thickness of the branches' would barely allow the 'north or east winds to penetrate'. One day, Akbar and his men caught as many as seventy elephants. The padishah was delighted, but the hunt had gone on so long it was too late to return for the night. Instead, his carpenters built a cosy little camp in the forest: a wooden platform spread with 'scarlet cloth'. On it slept Akbar, encircled by his companions, including his best friend and milk brother Aziz, Shamsuddin Ataka's son.[27]

The next morning, while he waited for a troop of tame elephants to arrive from his main camp – they were needed to escort their wild, captured fellows from the forest – Akbar treated himself to another kind of entertainment. Seated with his friends on his wooden perch, Akbar called for Darbar Khan, his *dastango*, to come and tell him stories. So, to the sound of magic tales in the dense forest, with thoughts of his wonderful new menagerie in mind, the elephant-catching, rebel-subduing, kingdom-usurping padishah took a short pause in the endless adventure of his own life.

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The interlude could not last forever. The camp marched on. The monsoon had broken; there was lightning and flooding, and a 'vicious mud' that